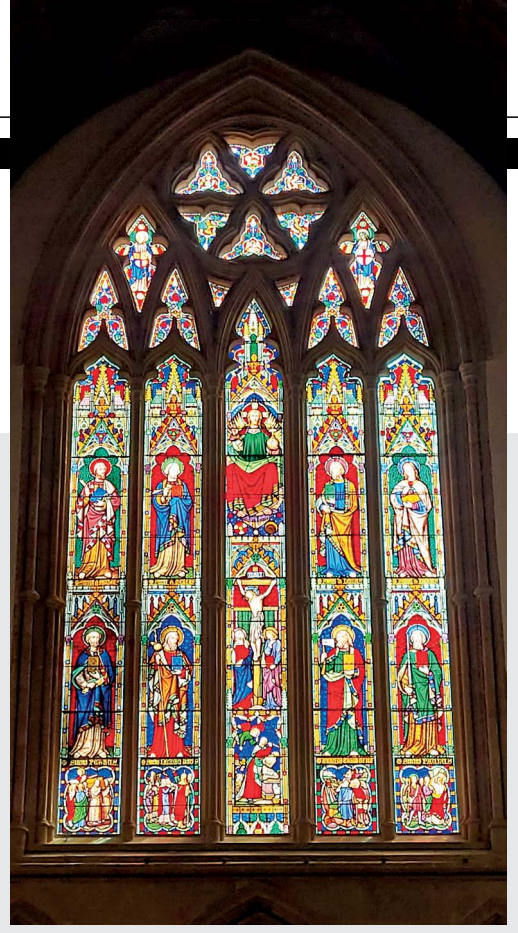
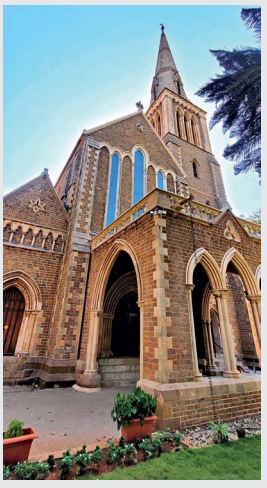
ARCHITECTURE

Steeple *Chase*

Mumbai's **Afghan Church** is poised to become a major tourist attraction after being restored





PRIYA PATHIYAN

CONSERVING HERITAGE The towering steeple and (right) a stained-glass panel at Afghan Church in Colaba, Mumbai

While most Mumbaikars are aware of the main British colonial monuments in South Mumbai, many are only now waking up to the existence of an Anglican church located at the southernmost tip of the city inside the Colaba military station, thanks to its recent restoration. The Church of St John the Evangelist was built between 1847 and 1858 and later came to be known as the Afghan Church. "Many Mumbaikars find it amusing that their city has an 'Afghan' Church. Interestingly, it was not built for the Afghans but in memory of the British soldiers who died in the first Anglo-Afghan War (1838-42)," explains Bharat Gothoskar, heritage evangelist and founder of Khaki Tours.

The Church of St John the Evangelist was built between 1847 and 1858 and later came to be known as the Afghan Church

When you visit today, the towering steeple set amidst expansive grounds, the stunning arches and unbelievably beautiful stained-glass panels above the altar and entrance, the floral design of the iron screen that was created by the students of the Sir JJ School of Art & Architecture when the church was built, the original Minton tiles inside the pulpit, and many such aspects of the church draw the eye. Conservation architect Kirtida Unwalla, who has been working on the church on and off for almost 30 years (barring the past decade), has spearheaded this recent renaissance.

Gothoskar observes, "Inaugurated in 1858, it was not only one of the earliest neo-Gothic buildings in Mumbai but also the first to extensively use stained-glass windows. If this building is opened every day for tourists with guided tours, it will become a major attraction." Perhaps it is with this intent that a small interpretation centre has been created near the entrance. The windows by famous British stained-glass maker William Wailes have been given a new lease of life by stained-glass expert Swati Chandgadkar. The ornate *reredos* (the screen behind the altar) with its mosaic tiles, the wide wooden chairs with their rattan weave, and the glorious row of vertical windows would all be fascinating to visitors. Lighting designer Kanchan Puri's illumination allows you to appreciate the external architecture at night as well.

Unwalla elaborates, "We had never been able to look at it as a holistic building. We used to only work on it in bits and parts as and when we got some funding." The Rs 14 crore funding from World Monuments Fund India allowed her team to restore and repair every inch of the building. "Earlier, the roof and walls were never touched. Now, we were able to work on the steeple too," says Unwalla.

With very few reference pictures to get the detailing right, Unwalla relied on an old book written by one of the Reverends who played a small role in the Afghan War. "He was the one who was instrumental in wanting this church to be dedicated to the soldiers who died in the war. Now, there are revelations about that time, so it's become culturally significant and has been graded the highest Grade-1 [conservation level]," she says. "That's why it should be recognised as a World [Heritage] monument. We'll work towards getting it granted that status." ■

–Priya Pathiyan